

THE WAY IT OFTEN ENDS
Rahul Kumar's mother Pinki Devi with a picture of her son, murdered in November by his girldfriend's brother, in Patna

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tures of their elders. This August, when Vishal Paswan of Vaishali eloped with his girlfriend Bandhan, they posted a video on social media refuting the abduction FIR filed on behalf of the girl's parents. The same month, Rupanjali Kumari of Darbhanga eloped with Raj Kumar Das and they married in a temple. In their video message, the couple actually showed their identity certificates to prove they were adults and that the abduction FIR against Raj Kumar was factually erroneous.

A PERSON IS MURDERED EVERY SECOND DAY IN BIHAR FOR LOVE AFFAIRS, MAKING THE STATE AMONG WORST IN INDIA ON THIS FRONT

These videos are a tactical move to make the cops, who are duty-bound to investigate any abduction FIR, go easy on the case. It also helps should they have to surrender in a court.

But a majority of eloping couples remain in hiding for months, fearing violent reprisal from families. If caste enters the equation, all bets are off. Acceptance or reconciliation is a rare thing, and most cases remain on the records as "crimes". One exception was scripted in August. The story began in February when Easha, a 21-year-old Brahmin girl, encountered Smit Raj, a 24-year-old boy from the Kurmi community, on Instagram. She was from Katihar, he from Bhagalpur—on the opposite banks of the Ganges, and with a river of caste between them. But they immediately liked each other, feelings that only grew after they met at a social function in Bhagalpur, where Easha had relatives. Her father, meanwhile, unaware of the blossoming romance, was rifling through marriage proposals for her, and had nearly zeroed in on one case. Easha had not much time to think and act. She went by gut instinct and eloped....

IT'S THE GIRL, STUPID

Before seeing how that story panned out, something about these cases the old society is fearful of admitting: the girl's consent and desire. The law's vocabulary fails to even account for it; it has only the macho crime of abduction to describe elopements. Dr Madhavi, assistant professor of sociology in Patna University, who worked on the changing patterns of Hindu marriages for her PhD, feels something revolutionary is germinating here. "Just speaking of girls and their willingness to elope is a massive variation registered in Bihar's society. The change in their mindset is unprecedented," says Dr Madhavi, who goes by a single name. Some obvious reasons—rising opportunities to study and work. for instance. With the state's 35 per cent reservations for girls in jobs, even rural parents have dropped their restraints and are encouraging their daughters